

Cursor Toolbox — Decision Guide

Which tool do I reach for?

I need to...	Use a...
Enforce a coding standard on every interaction	Rule (<code>alwaysApply: true</code>)
Enforce a standard for specific file types	Rule (scoped with glob pattern)
Run a repeatable multi-step workflow	Skill
Give one-time instructions for this task	Prompt (typed in chat)
Give Cursor access to live data or external tools	MCP Server
Not sure yet	Prompt first — promote when you've needed it 3×

The promotion rule:

- Typed it once → Prompt
- Typed it three times → Rule
- Multi-step process you repeat → Skill
- Cursor needs live external data → MCP

What makes a good rule?

- An **assertion**, not a request: "Use `async/await`" not "Please try to use `async/await`"
- **Scoped** appropriately: global rules add cost to every request; scope aggressively
- **Enforceable**: if you caught Cursor violating it, you'd send the code back
- **Not obvious**: rules that restate basic good practice are noise

What makes a good skill?

- A **clear trigger**: Cursor knows when to apply it
- A **step-by-step workflow**: specific enough to produce consistent output
- A **defined output format**: the artifact has a predictable shape
- **Minimal**: start with the least it needs to be useful; earn complexity through use

When to start a fresh conversation

- Starting a new task or feature
- After completing a checkpoint
- When Cursor keeps making the same mistake
- After 3-5 back-and-forth correction turns
- When response quality is noticeably degrading

Why it works: Each new conversation gets a clean context. The old back-and-forth — which encodes a failure pattern — is gone. Fresh brief, fresh start.

Plan > Code > Review

Phase	Mode	What you do
Plan	Plan mode	Write the brief, state constraints, define non-goals, get agreement
Code	Agent mode	One checkpoint at a time; reference rules; start fresh between checkpoints
Review	Ask mode or human eyes	Verify against brief; find what's wrong; decide what to keep

Never skip Plan for anything bigger than a bug fix.
Never accept output without Review.

What to never share with Cursor

- Credentials, API keys, passwords
- Customer PII or production data
- Proprietary trade secrets
- Internal security configurations

Use `.env` files and `.cursorignore` to keep these out of context.

The mCase Capstone — Quick Reference

Task	Tool	How
List all datalists	MCP	<code>schema</code> tool
Get datalist fields	MCP	<code>datalist_by_name</code> tool
Get relationships	MCP	<code>all_relationships</code> tool
Keep coding standards	Rules	<code>.cursor/rules/project-rules.mdc</code>
Write a stack ADR	Skill	<code>create-adr-simple</code>
Understand the MCP codebase	Skill	<code>ai-agent-documentation</code>